scattered implementation details. Instead, it can be examined, tested, and governed. The focus has shifted from preventing individual failures to ensuring that authority is exercised within clear, observable boundaries.

ACME's CIO, Ravi, considers authorization a fundamental part of the company's technical infrastructure. The authorization system, developed through incremental improvements, is now something ACME can intentionally build upon. New services are designed to rely on it. Emerging patterns, like cross-company delegation and agent-mediated workflows, are being explored within it. What was once an internal concern is becoming a capability that shapes how ACME engages in a broader ecosystem.

For Elena, ACME's CEO, the significance is clear. Authorization is no longer just a way to control access; it is a way to build trust at scale. It shapes how employees collaborate, how customers experience the platform, and how the company forms new partnerships. It allows ACME to support new types of automation and adapt to changing conditions without losing control over decision-making.

ACME's work is ongoing. The same forces that drove this architecture—growth, integration, automation, and greater dependence on real-time context—continue to develop. But the company now has something it lacked before: a solid foundation to build upon. What started as a series of small improvements has grown into a capability that shapes ACME's market position and its future.

19.9 Deciding continuously

Throughout this book, we have explored how authorization decisions are made: who can act, what they can do, and under what conditions. In many systems, these decisions are considered static. They are defined once, embedded in code or configuration, and assumed to remain unchanged until someone updates them. *That assumption no longer applies.*

As systems become more distributed, automated, and interconnected, authorization decisions need to be made continuously. They must consider changing relationships, shifting context, and actions taken by people,